

ART & CULTURE



INDIAN PAINTINGS

MODULE - 8

FOLK PAINTINGS

FOLK PAINTINGS IN INDIA

1

MADHUBANI PAINTINGS



Mithila region of Bihar

FOLK PAINTINGS IN INDIA

1

MADHUBANI PAINTINGS



*Hindu religious themes
were usually drawn*

1

Traditionally done by the **women of villages around Madhubani town**, it is also called Mithila paintings.

2

The art extends to the adjoining parts of Terai region in Nepal.

3

The paintings have a common theme and are usually drawn from **religious motifs of the Hindus**, including Krishna, Rama, Durga, Lakshmi and Shiva.

FOLK PAINTINGS IN INDIA

1

MADHUBANI PAINTINGS



Fish figurines symbolises good luck and fertility

4 The figures in the painting are symbolic, for example fish depicts good luck and fertility.

5 The paintings are made depicting auspicious occasions like birth, marriage and festivals. Flowers, trees, animals etc are used to fill any gaps in the painting.

6 Traditionally, these were painted on walls using rice paste and vegetable colours on a base of cow dung and mud.

FOLK PAINTINGS IN INDIA

1

MADHUBANI PAINTINGS



Double line border, bold colours were its characteristic features

7

With time, the base changed to **handmade paper, clothes and canvas**, still the natural colours were used.

8

Since there is no shading, the paintings are two-dimensional.

9

Some of the common features of these paintings include double line border, bold use of colours, ornate floral patterns and exaggerated facial features.

FOLK PAINTINGS IN INDIA

1

MADHUBANI PAINTINGS



Women passes on the skill from generation to generation

10 The origin of Madhubani paintings is believed to be during the period of Ramayana, **when the king of Mithila** told people of his kingdom to paint walls and floors of their houses **on the marriage of Sita and Rama**. The people believed that doing so should please the Gods.

11 Mostly, women have passed on the skill of Madhubani painting from generations to generations.

FOLK PAINTINGS IN INDIA

1

MADHUBANI PAINTINGS



Baula Devi with her Madhubani paintings

- 12 In 1975, this art got recognition, when the President of India honoured Jagadamba Devi with Padma Shri award.
- 13 Apart from her, other famous people associated with this include Baula Devi, Bharti Dayal, Ganga Devi and Sita Devi.
- 14 Since the art has remained confined to a specific geographical area, it has been given GI (Geographical Indication) status.

FOLK PAINTINGS IN INDIA

2

PATTACHITRA



Orissa region

FOLK PAINTINGS IN INDIA

2

PATTACHITRA



Lamp black



Hingula



Burnt coconut shells

1 A traditional painting of Odisha, the name Pattachitra come from a Sanskrit word **Patta**, which means **canvas/cloth** and **Chitra** means **picture**.

2 The paintings show **a mix of classical and folk elements**, with a bias towards the latter.

3 The base of the painting is treated cloth while the colours used come from natural sources including burnt coconut shells, Hingula, Ramaraja and lamp black.

FOLK PAINTINGS IN INDIA

2

PATTACHITRA



4 No pencil or charcoal is used, rather brush is used to draw the outlines in red or yellow after which the colours are filled.

5 The background is decorated with foliage and flowers and the paintings have a intricately worked frame.

6 Once the final lines are drawn, the painting is given a coating of lacquer to give it a glossy finish.

FOLK PAINTINGS IN INDIA

2

PATTACHITRA

7 The themes of these paintings are inspired from **Jagannath and Vaishnava** cult, sometimes from **Shakti and Shaiva** cults. Raghurajpur in Odisha is known for this art form.

8 The Pattachitra paintings depict images that are similar to the old murals of the State, especially the ones in Puri and Konark. **Pattachitra on leaf** is known as **Talapattachitra**.

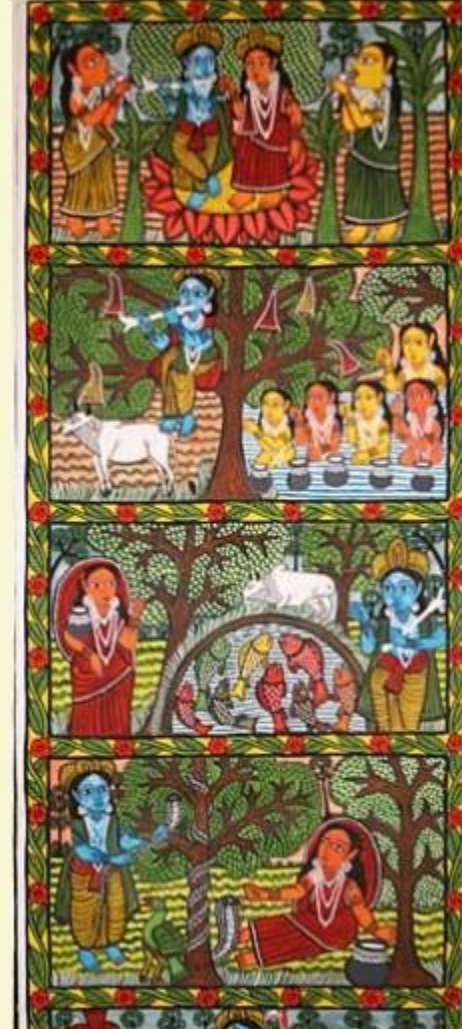
9 The hard dried leaves of palm tree are sewn together as a canvas on which images are drawn using white and black ink.

10 A number of times superimposing layers are glued together and some areas are left so that there are **small window like openings** that reveal second images under the first layer of the leaf

FOLK PAINTINGS IN INDIA

3

PATUA ART



West Bengal region

FOLK PAINTINGS IN INDIA

3

PATUA ART

- 1 The art of Bengal, Patua art dates back around a thousand years. It started out as a village tradition by painters of telling Mangal Kavyas or auspicious stories of Gods and Goddesses.

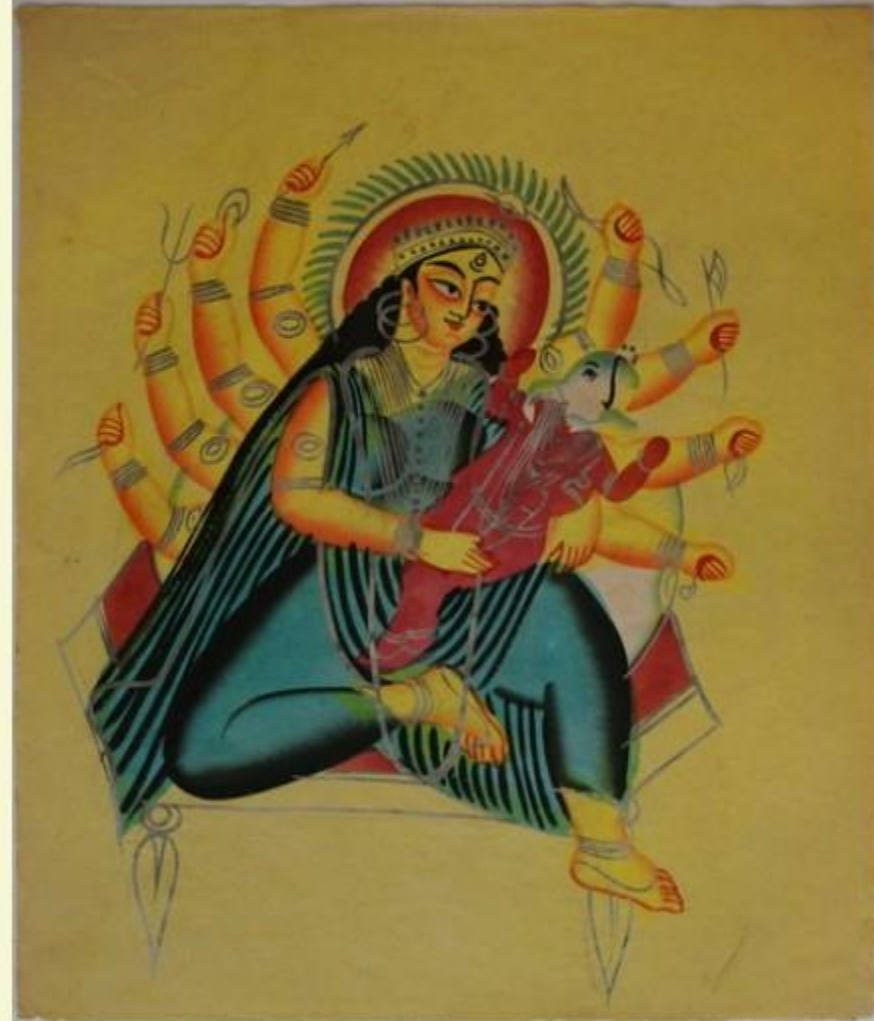


- 2 The subject of the paintings would be scenes from religious epics.
- 3 These paintings are done on pats or scrolls and for generations the scroll painters or patuas have been going to different villages to perform their stories in lieu of food or money.
- 4 Traditionally these were painted on cloth; today they are painted with poster paints on sheets of paper sewn together and are usually used to comment on political and social issues.

FOLK PAINTINGS IN INDIA

4

KALIGHAT PAINTING



Kolkatta region

FOLK PAINTINGS IN INDIA

4

KALIGHAT PAINTING



Ravana and Hanuman

- 1 A product of the changing urban society of Calcutta (now Kolkata), Kalighat paintings were done by the rural migrants who settled around the **Kalighat temple** in the then British capital (Calcutta).
- 2 Kalighat painting or Kalighat Pat originated in the late part of 19th century Bengal, in the vicinity of Kalighat Kali Temple, Kalighat, Kolkata, India, and from **being items of souvenir taken by the visitors to the Kali temple**, the paintings over a period of time developed as a distinct school of Indian painting.

FOLK PAINTINGS IN INDIA

4

KALIGHAT PAINTING



British entry to Bengal led to the growth of art

3

Initially the only school of painting that was flourishing in Bengal was the **traditional art of scroll paintings** that was popular in the rural areas. These paintings were done on cloth or patas.

4

These artists were called patuas or 'painters on cloth' and their work came to be known as **Patua art**.

5

Meanwhile, the British, having established themselves in the country politically started to evince interest in art, literature, and music.

FOLK PAINTINGS IN INDIA

4

KALIGHAT PAINTING



6

The **Calcutta School of Art** was one such school and attracted traditional artists—the patuas—to the city. Initially these artists were concentrated around the temple at Kalighat where there was a good demand for religious art.

7

Gradually, they started to learn from the newer techniques and discovered that these could help them increase their earnings. They **started creating new forms of art** and the Kalighat painting was born.

FOLK PAINTINGS IN INDIA

4

KALIGHAT PAINTING



Hindu gods were their favourite themes

- 8 Watercolors were used on mill paper using brushers made of calf and squirrel hair.
- 9 The painted figures has a plaque-like effect on neutral background given the shaded contours and articulated movements.
- 10 Originally, the paintings depicted religious note, especially Hindu Gods and Goddesses.

FOLK PAINTINGS IN INDIA

4

KALIGHAT PAINTING



CHAITANYA MAHAPRABHU

- He was a Hindu mystic, saint, and a proponent of Vaishnavism tradition within Hinduism.
- He also popularized the chanting of Hare Krishna Mantra and singing of Kirtans and Bhajans.

11 Among the deities that the Kalighat artists painted, **the goddess Kali was a favorite**. Images of Durga, Lakshmi, and Annapurna were also popular, especially during the Durga Puja festival.

12 Another theme depicted, dear to the Bengali ethos, was that of **Chaitanya Mahaprabhu and his disciples**.

13 Over time, these paintings were used **to express social sentiments**. Kalighat paintings are considered one of its kind in the country to **express subaltern sentiments and address customers directly**.

FOLK PAINTINGS IN INDIA

4

KALIGHAT PAINTING



Satirical themes also began to be depicted

- 14** In the more recent works **one can see changing roles of women and men**. Once education for women was introduced, **romantic depictions of women and satirical paintings** indicating the hypocrisies of newly rich.
- 15** Some believe that these paintings have been influenced by the distinctive painting style of the British, while the others focus on the **importance of social context and local technique** playing a major role in the style of the paintings.
- 16** This legacy of painting was long ignored by scholars, however it gained importance and appreciation in the **20th century**.

FOLK PAINTINGS IN INDIA

IMPORTANT PERSONALITY OF BENGALI FOLK ART – JAMINI ROY



Jamini Roy

- 1** He was a renowned painter who in the 1920s ushered a new style incorporating the Kalighat style and style of village Patua artists of Bengal.
- 2** His paintings involved use of inexpensive materials as by folk artists (rather than oil and canvas) and painted ordinary men and women from the village.
- 3** He was one of the most famous pupils of Abanindranath Tagore.

FOLK PAINTINGS IN INDIA

IMPORTANT PERSONALITY OF BENGALI FOLK ART – JAMINI ROY

- 4** The use of colours was limited to seven earthy or mineral colours: blue, Indian red, yellow ochre, grey, cadmium green, vermillion, and white.

- 5** Famous paintings include, Santhal Dance, Mother and Child, Gopini, Three Ladies etc.



Above: "Three Ladies"

Right side: "Mother and Child"



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